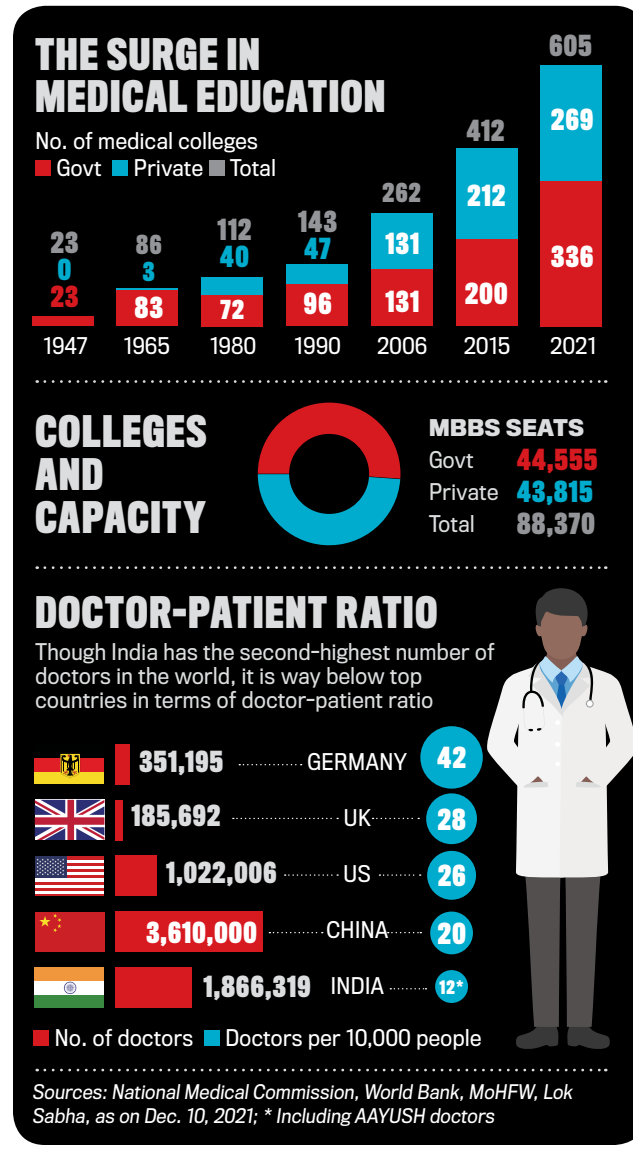


RELIEVED BUT ANXIOUS
A father hugs his son as he returns from crisis-hit Ukraine on Feb. 28

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

Uzhhorod is a world apart, and nearly 6,000 kilometres, from Chhindwara in Madhya Pradesh. Truth be told, you may not even have heard of the place even in India's metros. Unless of course you were seeking a medical degree, and a simple Google search for a cheaper option to acquire an MBBS qualification threw up the west Ukrainian city among the possibilities. At least that is how Chhindwara resident Arshpreet Kaur, 21, found herself at the Uzhhorod National Medical University two years back, and now, in her second year of medicine, was caught stranded, first in a war zone, and now professionally as well. When a belligerent Vladimir Putin, the Russian president, decided to invade Ukraine, Arshdeep was among the 18,000 Indian medical students in the country who were rescued as part of Operation Ganga.

But though the Indian government's initiative brought Arshdeep safely back home on March 6, the uncertainty of her future haunts her ceaselessly. Will she ever be able to return and complete her degree? Particularly as many of these students were castigated on social media for having brought the situation upon themselves by chasing a foreign degree when they could just as well have stayed behind in their own country and studied in one of its medical colleges.

Why don't these students choose to do so? Students who get a medical degree from a foreign country need to clear the Foreign Medical Graduates Exam (FMGE) in order to register and practise in India. Soon, the exam, to